

❖ STUDY BEES ❖

POEM – RUBAIYAT OF OMAR KHAYYAM

by

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About the Poem

The *Rubáiyát of Omar Khayyám* is Edward FitzGerald's celebrated English rendering of quatrains attributed to the 11th-century Persian poet, mathematician and astronomer Omar Khayyám. Each *rubá'i* (plural *rubáiyát*) is a self-contained four-line stanza built around a single reflection. The five quatrains covered here move from a vivid image of daybreak, through meditations on the emptiness of worldly ambition, the unknowable mysteries of existence, the unchangeable nature of fate, and finally a wistful lament for the fading of youth and beauty.

Paraphrasing

Stanza 1:

*Wake! For the Sun, who scattered into flight
has flung the stone that puts the stars to flight,
and Lo, the hunter of the east has caught,
The Sultan's Turret in a noose of Light.*

Paraphrasing:

The poem opens at daybreak: the sun is imagined driving away the stars as though flinging a stone to scatter them, while the rising sun itself is pictured as a hunter from the east who “catches” the Sultan's tower, wrapping it in a “noose of Light” as the first rays strike it. The stanza calls the reader to “wake” both to the new day and, symbolically, to a fresh awareness of life.

Stanza 2:

*The Worldly Hope men set their Hearts upon
Turns Ashes—or it prospers; and anon,
Like Snow upon the Desert's dusty Face,
Lighting a little hour or two—is gone.*

Paraphrasing:

The poet reflects that whatever worldly hope people pin their hearts on either comes to nothing (“turns Ashes”) or, even if it succeeds for a while, is soon gone – just as snow that briefly settles on the dusty desert ground melts away again within an hour or two. Worldly success, however real it may feel, is shown to be just as fleeting as that snow.

Stanza 3:

*There was the Door to which I found no Key;
There was the Veil through which I could not see:
Some little talk awhile of Me and Thee
There was—and then no more of Thee and Me.*

Paraphrasing:

The poet speaks of a door he could never unlock and a veil he could never see beyond – symbols of the deepest mysteries of existence, such as the meaning of life or what lies beyond death, which remain forever closed to human understanding. He also reflects that there was only a brief spell of conversation and companionship (“Me and Thee”) before that, too, ended, leaving nothing more of “Thee and Me” together.

Stanza 4:

*The Moving Finger writes; and, having writ,
Moves on: nor all your Piety nor Wit
Shall lure it back to cancel half a Line,
Nor all your Tears wash out a Word of it.*

Paraphrasing:

Using the image of an unseen hand writing out the events of fate, the poet declares that once something has been “written” – that is, once it has happened – nothing can call it back. Neither great devotion nor great cleverness can undo even half a line of what has occurred, and no amount of weeping can erase a single word of it: life’s events, once past, are permanent and irreversible.

Stanza 5:

*Yet Ah, that Spring should vanish with the Rose!
That Youth's sweet-scented manuscript should close!
The Nightingale that in the branches sang,
Ah, whence, and whither flown again, who knows*

Paraphrasing:

The poet laments that spring must fade away along with the rose, and that the fresh promise of youth – pictured as a “sweet-scented manuscript” – must eventually close, like a book coming to its end. He wonders, with quiet sorrow, about the nightingale that once sang among the branches: where it came from, and where it has now flown, no one can say – an image for the fleeting, unrecoverable nature of youth, beauty, and joy.

Rhyming Scheme

Each quatrain generally follows the distinctive “Rubaiyat rhyme scheme,” AABA: the first, second, and fourth lines rhyme, while the third line stands apart, unrhymed. This gives each four-line stanza a sense of near-completeness with a subtle turn at the third line. The third stanza (“There was the Door to which I found no Key”) is a well-known exception, where all four lines rhyme together (*Key / see / Thee / me*),

producing an unusually tight, circling effect that suits its meditation on a closed, unanswerable mystery.

Theme

Across these five quatrains, the *Rubáiyát* meditates on the brevity and mystery of human life. Worldly ambition fades as quickly as melting snow; the deepest questions about existence remain forever locked behind an unopened door and an impenetrable veil; fate, once set in motion, cannot be undone by any amount of piety or grief; and even youth and beauty – like the rose, the spring, and the nightingale's song – must inevitably fade and disappear, leaving only unanswerable questions behind. Together, the stanzas capture Khayyam's central, wistful meditation on time, impermanence, and the limits of human understanding.

Figures of Speech

• Personification

The rising sun is personified as “the hunter of the east,” who “catches” the Sultan's turret in a “noose of Light,” turning a natural event into a vivid, almost mythic action.

• Metaphor

Fate is figured as a “Moving Finger” writing an unchangeable script; life's deepest mysteries are figured as a locked “Door” and an impenetrable “Veil”; youth's promise is figured as a “sweet-scented manuscript.”

• Simile

Worldly hope's brief success is compared directly to snow settling on the desert's “dusty Face,” which melts away within “a little hour or two.”

• Symbolism

The rose and spring symbolise youth and beauty; the nightingale symbolises fleeting joy and song; the door and veil symbolise the unknowable mysteries of existence and death.

• Rhetorical Question

“Ah, whence, and whither flown again, who knows” voices the poet's unanswered wonder at where beauty and youth ultimately go once they vanish.

• Imagery

Strong visual imagery – sunlight catching a turret, melting snow on desert sand, a nightingale singing among branches – grounds each stanza's abstract reflection in a concrete picture.

• Exclamation / Apostrophe

Emotional exclamations such as “Yet Ah, that Spring should vanish with the Rose!” give the final stanza a tone of heartfelt, direct lament.

Questions & Answers

Q1. How is the sunrise described in the first stanza?

The sun is personified as “the hunter of the east,” scattering the stars like a flung stone and catching the Sultan's turret in a “noose of Light” as dawn breaks.

Q2. What does the second stanza say happens to worldly hope?

It either comes to nothing (“turns Ashes”) or briefly prospers before vanishing, just like snow on the desert that melts away within an hour or two.

Q3. What do the “Door” and the “Veil” represent in the third stanza?

They represent the deepest mysteries of existence – truths about life, fate, or death – that remain forever locked away and hidden from human understanding.

Q4. What is unusual about the rhyme scheme of the third stanza?

Unlike the poem's typical AABA pattern, all four lines of this stanza rhyme together (*Key / see / Thee / me*), creating an especially tight, circling effect.

Q5. What does the image of the “Moving Finger” represent in the fourth stanza?

It represents fate or destiny as something already “written” and unchangeable – once events occur, no devotion, wit, or tears can undo or erase them.

Q6. What does the poet compare youth to in the final stanza?

He compares youth to a “sweet-scented manuscript” that must eventually close, and links its fading to the vanishing of spring, the rose, and the nightingale's song.

Q7. What unanswered question closes the final stanza?

The poet wonders where the nightingale came from and where it has flown now that its song has ended – “Ah, whence, and whither flown again, who knows.”

Q8. What is the central theme running through all five stanzas?

The brevity and mystery of human life: worldly hope, existence's deepest questions, fate, and even youth and beauty are all shown to be fleeting, unchangeable, or ultimately unknowable.